History of Cricket in India

Introduction

Cricket is India's most popular sport, followed by hundreds of millions of people, and it is often called a religion in the country. The game came to India with British sailors and soldiers in the 18th century. The first recorded cricket match in India was played in 1721 by British sailors at Cambay in Gujarat, and the Calcutta Cricket Club, founded in 1792, is the oldest cricket club outside England. The Parsi community of Bombay was the first Indian community to take up the sport, forming the Oriental Cricket Club in 1848, and princely states, with players such as Ranjitsinhji and Duleepsinhji (who played for England), nurtured the game. The Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) was formed in 1928, and the national domestic championship, the Ranji Trophy, started in 1934, named after Ranjitsinhji.

India's Early Test Journey

India played its first Test match in June 1932 at Lord's in London, led by Colonel C. K. Nayudu, the first captain of India. India's first Test victory came on 10 February 1952 at the Chepauk stadium in Madras (now Chennai), when India beat England by an innings and eight runs, with a stellar performance by spinner Vinoo Mankad. India's first Test series wins abroad were in 1971, in the West Indies and England, under captain Ajit Wadekar. The famous Indian spin quartet of Bishan Singh Bedi, E. A. S. Prasanna from Karnataka, B. S. Chandrasekhar and S. Venkataraghavan, from Chennai, ruled the 1960s and 1970s. Sunil Gavaskar became the first batter to score 10,000 Test runs in 1987.

When Did India Win Its First Cricket World Cup?

India won its first Cricket World Cup in 1983. The third edition of the tournament, the Prudential World Cup, was held in England, and India, who were not considered favourites, with odds against them of 66 to 1, defeated the two-time champions, the West Indies, in the final at Lord's on 25 June 1983. India scored only 183 in the final, and bowled out the West Indies for 140, winning by 43 runs. Mohinder Amarnath, who was named Man of the Match, and Madan Lal took key wickets. The famous catch of Viv Richards by Kapil Dev turned the game. Earlier in the tournament, Kapil Dev made an unbeaten 175 against Zimbabwe at Tunbridge Wells, one of the greatest innings in one-day cricket, rescuing India from 17 for 5.

Who Was the Captain?

The captain of the 1983 World Cup-winning team was Kapil Dev, the all-rounder who was only 24 years old. The squad included Sunil Gavaskar, Krishnamachari Srikkanth from Chennai, Mohinder Amarnath, Sandeep Patil, Yashpal Sharma, Roger Binny, Madan Lal, Kirti Azad, Syed Kirmani, Ravi Shastri, Balwinder Sandhu and Sunil Valson. The win inspired a generation of Indians to take up cricket and changed the game's economics in India, and is portrayed in the film "83" (2021).

India's Other Major Wins

India won the inaugural ICC World Twenty20 in South Africa in 2007 under a young captain, Mahendra Singh Dhoni, defeating Pakistan in the final in Johannesburg. India won the 50-over World Cup for the second time on 2 April 2011 at the Wankhede Stadium in Mumbai, beating Sri Lanka by six wickets, with Dhoni hitting the winning six. India won the ICC Champions Trophy in 2013 in England under Dhoni, making him the only captain to win all three ICC trophies at the time, and again in 2025 under Rohit Sharma, beating New Zealand in the final in Dubai on 9 March 2025. India won the T20 World Cup for a second time in June 2024 in Barbados, beating South Africa in the final by seven runs, under Rohit Sharma, with Virat Kohli's 76 and Jasprit Bumrah's bowling. The Indian women's team, led by Harmanpreet Kaur, won the Women's ODI World Cup for the first time in November 2025, defeating South Africa in the final in Navi Mumbai. India has also been a finalist in the World Test Championship.

What Is the IPL?

The IPL, or Indian Premier League, is a professional Twenty20 (T20) cricket league in India, run by the BCCI, in which franchise teams representing Indian cities compete every year, usually from March to May. It was launched in 2008, the brainchild of Lalit Modi, and the first season began on 18 April 2008 with a match at Bengaluru, with Brendon McCullum scoring 158 for Kolkata Knight Riders. The inaugural champion was the Rajasthan Royals, led by Shane Warne. The IPL combines cricket with entertainment, attracting top players from all over the world and young Indian talent. It began with eight franchises and now has ten, including the Chennai Super Kings (CSK), Mumbai Indians (MI), Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB), Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR), Delhi Capitals, Sunrisers Hyderabad, Rajasthan Royals, Punjab Kings, Gujarat Titans and Lucknow Super Giants. Mumbai Indians and Chennai Super Kings are the most successful teams, with five titles each, while Royal Challengers Bengaluru won their first title in 2025. The IPL's media rights were sold for more than Rs. 48,000 crore for five years from 2023, making it one of the most valuable sports leagues in the world per match. An auction is held each year in which the franchises buy players.

Cricket in Tamil Nadu and Chennai

Chennai has a rich cricketing heritage. The M. A. Chidambaram Stadium at Chepauk, one of the oldest in India, hosted India's first Test win in 1952 and the famous tied Test between India and Australia in September 1986, only the second tied Test in cricket history. Chepauk is the home of the Chennai Super Kings, led by M. S. Dhoni, who is revered in Chennai as "Thala"; CSK have won the IPL five times, in 2010, 2011, 2018, 2021 and 2023. Famous Tamil Nadu cricketers include Krishnamachari Srikkanth, a 1983 World Cup winner, S. Venkataraghavan, W. V. Raman, Ravichandran Ashwin, who took over 500 Test wickets, Murali Vijay, Dinesh Karthik, Washington Sundar, T. Natarajan and Varun Chakravarthy. The Tamil Nadu Premier League is a state-level T20 tournament.

Famous Indian Players

Indian cricket legends include Sunil Gavaskar, Kapil Dev, Sachin Tendulkar, known as the "Master Blaster", who scored 100 international centuries and played 200 Test matches, Rahul Dravid, Sourav Ganguly, Anil Kumble, Virender Sehwag, Virat Kohli, Rohit Sharma, MS Dhoni, Jasprit Bumrah and women such as Mithali Raj and Jhulan Goswami. Cricket is set to feature in the Olympics for the first time since 1900 at the Los Angeles Olympics in 2028, in the T20 format.

Challenges and Future

Challenges include the busy schedule, balancing the three formats, player workload, and ensuring the growth of women's cricket through the Women's Premier League, started in 2023. The future includes global growth and the inclusion in the Olympics.

Quick Facts

- India won its first Cricket World Cup in 1983 at Lord's, beating the West Indies by 43 runs.
- Kapil Dev was the captain of India's 1983 team; M. S. Dhoni captained the 2011 World Cup-winning team.
- The IPL (Indian Premier League) is a T20 league launched by the BCCI in 2008; Rajasthan Royals won the first season.
- India's first Test win was against England in Madras in February 1952.
- Chennai Super Kings have won five IPL titles.